

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • LESSON 1 OF 6

How to Talk to AI



45 minutes, no prep. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants what you SAID, not what you MEANT. Students learn both human jobs in every AI task: the prompt and the check. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (2 pages, 1 per student; typeable PDF included) · Slides (optional) · board for P.R.O. · Teacher Guide (Scoring Guidance, P.R.O. sentence starters) · pens	None — runs fully unplugged. Optional: a projector for the slides; one AI tool on your screen for the Showcase	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.3.b

CCSS ELA W.6.4

- Explain why the same AI answers a vague prompt worse than a clear one. (*Exit Ticket #1, part two*)
- Apply **P.R.O.** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt. (*Wish repairs 1–3; Exit Ticket #1*)
- Evaluate a sample AI answer: find the checkable claim and where to check it. (*Exit Ticket #2*)

✦ WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (8 MIN)

You are a genie who grants wishes *exactly as worded*. Take 3–4 wishes and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now Rich."

"I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted — one million dollars, in play money."

"I wish school was over." → "Granted. The school building is now over... there."

Then ask: **"Whose fault was that — the genie's, or the wish?"** Bridge: "AI works like that genie. It doesn't know what you MEANT — it only knows what you SAID. Every AI job goes human, AI, human: you start it with the wish, the genie does the middle, and you check what comes back. Today you get good at both human parts."

What if a wish is inappropriate? Don't play it: "The genie doesn't grant that one. Next wish." Nobody volunteers? Wish first yourself: "I wish for a snack" → "Granted: one grain of rice."

Transition: "So how do you write a wish a genie can't twist? Lawyers figured this out a long time ago."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — PARTS OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (10 MIN)

Lawyers make contracts genie-proof with clauses. Strong prompts have three parts — write **P.R.O.** on the board as you go:

P — Purpose. What you want + who it's for. "Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader" beats "explain photosynthesis."

R — Requirements. The rules: length, tone, format, include / leave out. This is what stops the twist.

O — Output. What should the finished answer look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Watch one get fixed — build the repair on the board, naming each part as you add it. **Cursed wish:** "help with my history essay" → **Genie-proof P.R.O. prompt:** "I'm writing a 7th grade history essay on the printing press. Give me 3 thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write it for me."

Say it plainly (Direct Instruction, continued): "See the last sentence — *don't write it for me*. AI is your editor, not your ghostwriter. It gives a second opinion on YOUR work; it doesn't hand in work with your name on it."

What if *someone says the fixed prompt is "too long"? Count it: three sentences. "Three sentences now, or forty pages of NASA history later. Your call."*

Hand-out / transition: "Your turn. Page 1: three kids typed cursed wishes. Fix all three — every part, P, R and O, every time. Solo. Ten minutes."

ACTIVITY — CURSED WISH REPAIR SHOP (22 MIN)

1. **Repair (10 min):** Solo, students fix Amara's, Mateo's and Yuki's cursed wishes on page 1 with all three P.R.O. parts. Circulate; read a stuck student's repair aloud in a genie voice.

What if *a student writes nearly the same repair three times? "What does Mateo need that Yuki doesn't?" A plan is not a story — O must change. **Finished early?** Extension below.*

Swap: "Pens down. Swap sheets with your partner. You are now the Worst Genie Ever, and page 2 is where you do your damage."

2. **Break it (7 min):** Pairs swap sheets and play the Worst Genie Ever on page 2 of their PARTNER's sheet: say a twist out loud for each wish, tick the Genie-Proof Checklist, write the best twist, swap back. Twistable = needs more rules.

What if *a partner ticks every box without trying? Make them say the twist out loud. Can't twist it — the ✓ stands. Can twist it — un-tick and write the twist.*

Swap back: "Sheets back with their owners. Genies, point at the ONE wish on your partner's sheet you could NOT twist. That's the one we want to hear."

3. **Showcase (5 min):** 2–3 pairs read a "cursed → genie-proof" before-and-after. With devices: run the best one live and critique what comes back.

What if *the live AI answer is bad anyway? Perfect — "Which part of the wish let it do that?" The class adds a rule and you run it again.*

Into the exit ticket: "Your OWN sheet, bottom of page 2. Before you write, one more rule about genies."

EXIT TICKET — LAST CHECK (5 MIN: 1 + 4)

First minute — the trickster rule: "Genies are tricksters. AI can grant your wish with made-up facts, and sound sure. Anything checkable — a name, a date, a number — gets checked somewhere real before you use it." **Four minutes, solo:** #1 a genie-proof prompt for another class + what the genie would have done with the short version; #2 the printed genie answer to Amara's wish — which line to double-check, and where. Collect; key in the Teacher Guide only.

What if *a student says "it all sounds right"? "Which line has a number or a date in it? Numbers and dates are checkable. Start there."*

DIFFERENTIATION

- **Support:** P.R.O. sentence starters (Teacher Guide);
- **Extension:** Write a wish that CAN'T be genie-proofed in under 50 words — then explain why.
- **ELL:** The sentence starters double as language frames; draft in the strongest language first, then translate.
- **No-device classrooms:** Built in — the teacher and partners ARE the genie. Skip the "with devices" lines.